

ANI

THE AAP TEAM Arvind Kejriwal, Mann and Raghav Chadha

AAP REPORT CARD

What the party promised and what it has achieved in the one year of its rule in Punjab

↘ Upgrading 117 government schools as 'schools of eminence'

Status: Project launched in January end

↘ *Setting up 500 'Aam Aadmi clinics' on the lines of the successful mohalla clinics in the national capital by converting non-functional Sewa Kendras*

Status: Hobbled by lack of trained medical staff

↘ *Slashing load enhancement fee on tube-wells from Rs 4,750 to Rs 2,500 per bhp*

Status: Done

↘ *Declared minimum support price for moong in July*

Status: Only 11 per cent of produce procured at MSP rate so far

↘ *300 units of free electricity per month*

Status: Done

↘ *Government Volvo buses from 10 cities to Delhi airport*

Status: 25 buses plying daily

↘ *Regularising certain temporary government jobs, including over 8,000 teachers*

Status: Done

↘ *Implementing old pension scheme (OPS)*

Status: Committee formed under state chief secretary Vijay Kumar Janjua to implement it; funds will be a problem

↘ *Crackdown on illegal encroachments*

Status: Initial momentum now flagging

↘ *Withdrawal of security cover to 424 VIPs announced on May 27, 2022*

Status: Done. AAP leaders share names of leaders and prominent personalities. Among them is Sidhu Moosewala, who is killed the next day

↘ *Anti-gangster task force formed in April 2022 after a spate of murders*

Status: Mixed results. Most of the prize catches still made by Delhi Police and central agencies

ensure that he is not profligate while implementing his party's election promises.

A stable political environment is the second imperative for the Mann government. Radicals like Amritpal are gaining traction because of the space vacated by mainstream parties. The issues of unemployment and drug addiction arising out of the state's overall economic decline make the ground even more fertile for them to plant the seeds of unrest. People like Amritpal win supporters by focusing on government inefficiency and corruption as the root causes of Punjab's woes, unlike his idol Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale, who focused on social reform even as he radicalised Sikh youth. Noted security expert Ajai Sahni, in an article in *The Tribune*, writes that there are perceptions that the BJP-ruled Centre is seeking to destabilise the fledgling AAP government in Punjab. He believes the Centre's argument that law and order is a state subject, thereby leaving Amritpal's rabid radicalism for the Mann government to handle, is "unconvincing". He also points out that the "BJP's broad Hindutva project creates a reflexive justification for Khalistani separation. If the demand for a Hindu India is legitimate, so must be the demand for a Sikh's Khalistan".

Meanwhile, as he enters the second year of his chief ministership, Mann himself has to get a firm grip on the administration. He has reportedly alienated sections of the bureaucracy and the police with some allegedly arbitrary actions against them. The Ajnala incident showed the lack of firmness on the part of the Mann government in dealing with what was clearly a law and order issue. In the first place, the state government should have had backchannel negotiations on how to prevent such a blow-up and when it did take place, to have dealt with it firmly and prosecuted the blatant transgressors of the law.

The AAP government and other moderate parties also need to come up with a narrative that can pacify the air being vitiated by radicalised Sikh groups and remind people of the horrific consequences of feeding a Frankenstein monster once again with the old wounds barely healed. Says Pramod Kumar: "There is an urgent need for the Centre and the state to delegitimise violence and guns." Meanwhile, Punjab should focus on rapid economic development so that the energies of the restive youth are channelised towards productive activity. Punjab is once again at a difficult crossroads. The Centre and the state will have to work in tandem to prevent its descent into chaos and make Punjab prosperous again. ■